

Tech Help Sites

Another alternative is to visit tech help sites and forums and post the problem. A tech support site without a forum is hard to come across. Unlike manufacturers with a dedicated (and paid) team to answer user queries, forums leverage the knowledge pool existing in its user base for answers. It is the community spirit all along the members that drive a forum.

It needs to be noted that there are Web sites dedicated to problem solving. Besides, there are tech review Web sites that do not primarily focus on tech support, but also have a forum where tech savvy people can offer suggestions to resolve similar problems faced by other users. Being a popular destination for technophiles, a forum is a natural extension to such sites. For the purposes of this chapter, we shall not make a distinction between these two types of sites.

Identifying a “proper” forum

To promptly identify forums offering relevant solutions, one needs to look for clues such as the number of members, number of questions, number of topic categories and age of the forum.

The more the members, the better is the chance that you will get a better and quicker answer. But, if the site is old, the member strength could be misleading.

The number of queries/posts is a good indicator of the depth of the site. The larger the number, the greater the answer database and bet-



Screenshot 5 : Computers.ebay.in.jpg

ter the chance of finding a similar question answered previously.

The “weightage” of the subforums in a site is also an indicator of where the strength of the forum lies. A “tech” forum having the highest number of posts in a casual chat section is probably not the best place to expect a relevant answer to a tech problem. Sites that are spread too wide also can hide deficiencies—seeking an answer for a problem in C++ at a site with 90 per cent